

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1986-11-26

1 dear b ahá'í f riends,

The international Teaching center has referred to the universal house

2 of justice your letter of 29 September 1986 in which you seek comment on

3 the draft of the letter you plan to send to the local Spiritual Assembly of

4 . . . for the guidance of . . . , a believer who has written an article entitled, "The i
nfallibility of the p rophets."

5 The house of justice has studied your draft response and . . .'s paper

6 in which he concludes, by means of logical analysis, based in part on his
understanding of an article by mr. juan ricardo cole on the Tablet of wis-

7 dom, that bahá'u'lláh, and indeed all the prophets of god, are not infallible.

8 . . . expresses the opinion that attempts to resolve apparent contradictions in the
writings by seeking a broader context only serve to create insoluble

9 logical difficulties, and he indicates that he is aware that the institutions of

10 the faith may not agree with his views causing his status as a bahá'í to be

11 make the following reply.

12 . . .'s article raises fundamental issues about the station of the mani-

13 festations and Their authority, as well as about the nature of individual
interpretation.

14 it is clear from a study of the Text that infallibility is an essential attribute

15 of the m anifestation of g od. b ahá'u'lláh wrote:

. . . the most great infallibility is confined to the one whose sta-

tion is immeasurably exalted beyond ordinances or prohibitions and is

16 sanctified from errors and omissions. . . .

17 . . . were he to pronounce right to be wrong or denial to be belief,

18 he speaketh the truth as bidden by god. This is a station wherein sins

19 or trespasses neither exist nor are mentioned.

20 (T ablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas, pp. 108, 109)

21 'Abdu'l-bahá, in Some Answered Questions, stresses the inseparability of
22 "essential infallibility" from the manifestation of god, and states:12.1

12 2

12 3

12 4

12 4a

12.512 4b

13 1986–1992 • The Six Year Plan

21 . . as the supreme manifestations certainly possess essential infal-
libility, therefore whatever emanates from Them is identical with the
truth, and conformable to reality. They are not under the shadow of
the former laws. whatever They say is the word of god, and whatever
They perform is an upright action.12-1

The following extract from a letter dated 11 january 1942 written on

22 behalf of the guardian to an individual believer underlines the vital link

23 between revelation and the infallibility of the manifestation:

regarding your bahá'í friend who does not fully understand the infal-

24 libility of the manifestation of god: you should influence that person

25 to study the matter more deeply, and to realize that the whole theory of divine
revelation rests on the infallibility of the prophet, be he

christ, muḡammad, bahá'u'lláh, or one of the others. if They are not

26 infallible, then They are not divine, and thus lose that essential link

with god which, we believe, is the bond that educates men and causes

27 all human progress.

28 As to the infallibility of the content of bahá'u'lláh's revelation, . . . cites

29 issues concerning the chronology of philosophical figures mentioned in mr.

30 cole's article in the World Order magazine in 1979, as a basis for questioning

31 the infallibility of bahá'u'lláh. . . . appears to have misconstrued the tenor

32 of mr. cole's article. mr. cole's article does not challenge the infallibility

33 of bahá'u'lláh, on the contrary, he shows that bahá'u'lláh, himself, states

34 in the Tablet of wisdom that he is quoting the writings of past sages.

35 bahá'u'lláh wrote:

**Thou knowest full well that we perused not the books which men
possess and we acquired not the learning current amongst them, and
yet whenever we desire to quote the sayings of the learned and of the**

36 12-1. SA q, p. 173.12.5a

12 6

12 6a

12 7

12 7a

13 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

14 22wise, presently there will appear before the face of thy lord in the form

of a tablet all that which hath appeared in the world and is revealed

in the holy books and Scriptures. Thus do we set down in writing

that which the eye perceiveth. verily his knowledge encompasseth the

15 earth and the heavens.

(T ablets of Bahá'u'lláh Revealed after the Kitáb-i-Aqdas, p. 19)

16 mr. cole confirms this statement by comparison of the texts concerned.

17 There is nothing in the text of this Tablet to show conclusively whether, by quoting
these passages, bahá'u'lláh was intending to confirm their as-

18 sertions, or whether he was merely referring to historical authorities that

19 were accepted by the audience he was addressing. it must be borne in mind

20 that accounts of past events as recorded by historians of the east do not

21 always agree with the accounts set down by chroniclers in other parts of the

22 world. perhaps in the future studies will be undertaken to ascertain the facts

23 scientifically, if this is at all possible.

24 in reference to his revelation, bahá'u'lláh provides the following assur-

25 ance that when viewed from the perspective of the manifestation, the divine

26 purpose of the verses will become apparent and questions will be resolved:

The verses are sent down at one time in a form that is untroubled

27 by the rules of grammarians, transcending what the minds of men have yet
conceived; and at another time they are sent down in a style that conformeth to the standards
of men. Thy lord, verily, is potent

28 over whatsoever he willeth by virtue of his words “b e, and it is.” wert

thou to view them with mine eyes thou wouldst see that they are in

29 conformity with the most consummate rules, and wouldst give thanks to the lord, the
Almighty, the b est-b eloved.

(Newly translated)

30 As to the question of individual interpretation, while individual inter-
31 pretation is the fruit of man’s rational power and conducive to a better un-
32 derstanding of the teachings, the application of logical analysis has inherent
33 limitations. ‘Abdu’l-b ahá stated:

34 Therefore, if the criterion of reason or intellect constituted a correct

and infallible standard of judgment, those who tested and applied it

35 should have arrived at the same conclusions. As they differ and are 12.8

12 9

12 9a

12 10

12 10a

13 1986–1992 • T h e S i x Y e a r P l a n

14 2contradictory in conclusions, it is an evidence that the method and

15 standard of test must have been faulty and insufficient.

16 (The Promulgation of Universal Peace: T alks Delivered by ‘ Abdu’l-Bahá during

His Visit to the United States and Canada in 1912, p. 25)

understanding of the writings requires belief in the manifestation of

17 god, for, as the m aster states:

... the knowledge of god is the cause of spiritual progress and at-

traction, and through it the perception of truth, the exaltation of

humanity, divine civilization, rightness of morals and illumination

18 are obtained.

(Some Answered Questions, p. 00)

other important components in this process include an attitude of

19 prayerful humility, acceptance of the statements of the manifestation, con-

20 fidence in the knowledge that understanding of their meaning will emerge

21 with meditation, study of the texts and the passage of time, willingness to
acknowledge that one's views may be erroneous, and, courage to follow in the direction
defined by the authentic sacred texts.

22 The house of justice urges your National Spiritual Assembly to use the

23 guidance contained in this letter as a basis for guiding and educating the believer in
question about some of the fundamental verities of bahá'í belief

24 as a means of assisting him to determine his relationship to the faith. . . .

25 we are asked to assure you of the prayers of the house of justice for the

26 implementation of this weighty responsibility.

27 with loving bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

28 13

Conference on Huqúqu'lláh

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]